



Police use prediction algorithm for juvenile delinquency



By [Tweakers](#)

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Research by Follow the Money reveals that the Public Prosecution Service uses an algorithm to predict the likelihood of recidivism among minors. The system analyzes tens of thousands of young people annually.

The algorithm, which has been active within the National Juvenile Criminal Justice Chain Instrumentarium for ten years, calculates a risk score based on ten variables, including age, gender, and previous police records, reports *FTM*. Records such as witness, victim, or bystander are also taken into account, as well as police contacts of household members. The outcome influences whether a young person is placed in a Halt program or ends up in the criminal justice system.

The model was trained on data from 5,000 suspected youths, which, according to scientists from Radboud University who spoke with *FTM*, is too limited a dataset for reliable predictions. The predictions are particularly inaccurate for underrepresented groups such as 12-year-olds and girls. Researcher Joran van Apeldoorn of human rights organization Bits of Freedom analyzed the system and concluded that one in three youths is unfairly assigned a medium or high risk score. Additionally, the model is based solely on registered crime, which could create a distorted picture due to selective enforcement.

The Ministry of Justice and Security acknowledges the limitations to *FTM* but states that the system is 'reliable enough for the time being'. Following research by the University of Amsterdam, the algorithm is currently being further developed. Those involved, including youth lawyers, have not been informed about the use of this system until now.

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